# A Difficult Lesson

## By Tierra French

I should've seen it coming, but I didn't. I should've stopped it before things got this bad, but I couldn't. Now my baby girl is dead, and there's nothing I can do to change it. I guess I should take this story back about a year, but first, let me explain a few things.

My name is Rosa Lee Sherman. Me and my family have lived in Hopkinsville, Kentucky, since our ancestors planted roots here in the nineteenth century. I have a son, Joseph Lee Sherman, and, well, a daughter, Tonya Lee Sherman. Things seemed to be going pretty smoothly for my family – that is, until about a year ago.

## INTRODUCTION

*Dealing with discrimination, financial strain and the challenges of parenting their children alone, single black mothers often have difficulty finding support programs to help their families. Why? Very few exist. So moms are left to struggle alone, telling themselves that everything is fine, when they know that their kids are spirally out of control.*

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*As we work toward becoming a more inclusive society, we should consider how we address the special challenges single black mothers face. Support systems must be created to provide a safety net. No mother should have to learn such . . .*

*"A Difficult Lesson" by Tierra French*

Joseph Lee was a model student. He made good grades in school, was the captain of the junior debate team, and all in all, a fine son. Joseph even won a trophy for his many debates on the horror women experienced as a result of rape and sexual assault. But Joseph was what most teenagers would call an outsider. He didn't have many friends, and the ones he did have were closer to associates than real pals. He never went out to parties or spent the night over at a friend's house. He never talked on the phone or went to school functions, except for those debates he loved so much.

And then we had my daughter, Tonya Lee. Tonya and Joseph were like oil and vinegar. They hardly ever spoke to each other except to say, "Move," or "get out of my way." Tonya loved to party; child, that girl could

really ***party***! There were school nights when she kept me waiting up until four in the morning for her to come home. But through it all, she was my baby, and I loved her.

At this point Joseph was a junior in high school, and he was six feet-six inches at sixteen years old. Child, I tell you that boy was big, and I never thought nothing of it. I guess we had grown used to his size. At the beginning of the first semester, the basketball coach asked him to join the school team. I'll never forget that day Joseph came home grinning from ear to ear. It was the first time I'd seen him that happy in a long while. He said, "Mama, I'm finally gonna be accepted. Finally, I'm gonna be ***accepted***!"

The next day, Joseph went to try out for the team, and child, I tell you, he had a ball. The kids was right nice to him. Joseph told me the coach just loved him and guaranteed him a starting spot on the team! So, needless to say, Joseph began playing basketball for the school. It was like he was coming out of his shell. The

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boys on the team really liked him, or acted like they did, and Joseph began to hang around them more and more.

I noticed that Tonya was still rowdy and unpredictable as usual, but she was learning to like her brother a lot more, and the same with him. I even caught them one night in her room at one in the morning, talking and laughing with each other. That made me so happy, I just went into my room and cried tears of joy. Then Joseph started to hang out with the boys on the basketball team. They just went out for pizza occasionally, or to a movie, but gradually they became really close friends and Joseph started partying and hanging out almost more than Tonya Lee.

What I didn't know at the time was the kind of things this new group of "friends" were encouraging my son to do. Child, I swear to God if I had known I would have beaten every last one of them, then sent them running home to they mamas.

One afternoon, Joseph didn't come home from school, and I knew he was out there hanging out with his "friends." They were roaming the streets all night.

From what the police told me, they busted the windows out of someone's care, and they hid in some bushes and got caught.

Now I tell y'all, if I'da been in my right mind that boy would've gotten the whipping of his life and I would've made him spend the night in jail, but I picked him up and gave him a screaming about making me come out the house so late at night.

Well, I guess I thought that brush with jail would've been enough to make him not want to get in trouble with the law anymore, but that definitely did not work. It looked like every week the police were either knocking on my door or calling on my phone. Lord, I wish I could've stopped this before it got so big.

About a week before the prom, Joseph turned seventeen. To celebrate, he and his friends decided that they would throw a party, but they didn't have any money. I don't know whose bright idea it was, but they decided to rob a 7-Eleven. And they did it. No one was caught, but like my mama always told me, "what you do in the dark will eventually come to the light."

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I remember Joseph's prom night like it was yesterday. Tonya Lee had been invited by some friends, and she looked so pretty. Joseph even rented a tux even though he hadn't asked any girl to the prom. I took pictures of them and walked them out to the limousine, never imagining that my baby girl would not be coming back home that night.

Tonya and Joseph rode to the prom together, but they split up when they go there. Afterwards, Joseph met up with his friends from the basketball team. They dover up to a teen hangout called The Lot, which was really just an old parking lot where kids got drunk.

All night Joseph and his friends had been trying to get girls to sleep with them, but none would. Finally, they did something I thought my son would never do. One of the other boys grabbed a girl who was so far out of it, she was laying across the hood of a car. They put her in the backseat and placed a paper bag over her head so they wouldn't have to look at her. Each one took their turn with her. After Joseph's turn, one of his friends went back, and while he was having his way with

her, she woke up and started fighting. They boy tried to hold her down, but the paper bag fell off and she saw his face. He shot her in the head. Joseph heard the gunshot and ran to the car. The boy was already gone, but he found his sister . . . dead. My baby girl was dead in the car.

A week later my baby was buried, and all I could think about was how my son became the exact same thing that he so forcefully debated against: a rapist. The police had taken him and the other boys to jail, where they were being held until their court date.

At the funeral I cried, begging them not to take my baby away, but she was already gone. No matter how much I cried, it didn't change a thing. My baby girl was gone. Gone.

After Tony Lee died, I tried to pick my life up, what little I had left. Joseph and the other boys were charged with aggravated rape and were each sentenced to three years in prison.

Like this famous black guy used to say in the sixties, "If you don't stand for something, you will fall

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for anything." My Joseph just lost sight of everything he stood for. So he fell. But even at my age you still can learn how to stand on your principles, and for us, this has truly been a difficult lesson. Good-bye, Tonya Lee.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Tierra French***
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## AWARD HISTORY

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